



Social Psychology (SOCPSY)

Module 2: The Social Self

Self-Concept and Self-Esteem

Lesson Notes

KMVTECHUG

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Self-Concept

Self-concept is the sum of beliefs people have about themselves. These beliefs include social labels, physical labels, personal attributes, and general labels. The self-concept is organised through self-schemas: beliefs about yourself that guide how you process information related to you.

If you think of yourself as shy in large groups, a class presentation can trigger strong self-focused thoughts. The self acts as a frame of reference that influences thoughts, feelings, and behaviour.

Actual, Ideal, and Ought Self

The actual self is what you currently think you are. The ideal self is what you wish to be, or what a significant other wishes you to be. The ought self is what you believe you should be. People are motivated to reduce gaps between the actual self and these guides.

When the gap is large, discomfort can appear, and motivation to change behaviour can increase. Standards often come from family, culture, and peers, which is common in Ugandan student life.

Self-Esteem

Self-esteem is the evaluative part of the self: how positively or negatively you feel about yourself overall. It is not fixed forever. Feedback from performance, peers, family, and culture can raise or lower it. Healthy self-esteem is realistic, not blindly high or harshly low.

Reflect: Think of one standard you hold for yourself as a student. Is it closer to an ideal (what you wish) or an ought (what you feel you should be)?

Closing

Self-concept and self-esteem shape how you experience campus life. The next lesson looks at self-presentation.